

Impetigo

Patient Group Direction, version 002, issued 8 September 2026. Three arms: fusidic acid 2% cream, flucloxacillin oral suspension, and a macrolide where penicillin-allergic.

Choosing the arm

- **LOCALISED non-bullous impetigo, a few lesions in one area: fusidic acid 2% cream.**
- **WIDESPREAD non-bullous impetigo, BULLOUS impetigo, or failure of topical treatment: an oral antibiotic.**
- **Where an oral antibiotic is needed and the patient is NOT penicillin-allergic: flucloxacillin.**
- **Where an oral antibiotic is needed and the patient IS penicillin-allergic: clarithromycin, or erythromycin in pregnancy. This arm is new in version 002.**
- **DO NOT COMBINE a topical and an oral antibiotic. NICE is explicit on this and it is a common error.**
- **Courses are 5 DAYS. Version 001 gave 5 to 7 days throughout; 5 is the NICE course, extended to 7 only on clinical judgement where lesions are severe or numerous, and the reason recorded.**

What changed, and why

- **Version 001 authorised fusidic acid 2% cream and flucloxacillin 250mg/5ml oral suspension, and its flucloxacillin arm excluded penicillin allergy. There was no route at all for a penicillin-allergic patient with widespread or bullous impetigo.**
- **The consultation tool was filling that gap on its own, returning clarithromycin with a paediatric mg/kg dose. Clarithromycin appeared nowhere in the document, so those supplies had nothing authorising them. This version authorises the arm properly.**
- **A limitation to be aware of, carried forward from version 001 and not resolved here: the flucloxacillin arm is an oral SUSPENSION for children aged 3 months to 18 years. There is still no adult oral flucloxacillin arm. A penicillin-tolerant adult needing an oral antibiotic is referred. The macrolide arm below does cover adults.**

Hygiene advice, for every patient

- **Impetigo is contagious. Wash hands after touching the lesions and after applying any cream.**
- **Do not share towels, flannels or bedding until the lesions have crusted over or healed.**
- **Keep the lesions covered where practical, and discourage picking or scratching.**
- **Stay away from school or nursery until the lesions are crusted and dry, or for 48 hours after starting an antibiotic.**
- **Keep fingernails short.**

Fusidic acid 2% cream, for localised non-bullous impetigo

Patient Group Direction for the supply of fusidic acid 2% cream for the treatment of localised non-bullous impetigo.

Healthcare professionals covered, and training

- Pharmacist registered and practising with the GPhC.
- Pharmacy technician registered and practising with the GPhC.
- All users must be familiar with the current SPC for the product supplied, the BNF or BNF for Children, and NICE NG153 on impetigo.
- ALL USERS MUST BE ABLE TO DISTINGUISH LOCALISED FROM WIDESPREAD IMPETIGO, and non-bullous from bullous. Which arm applies turns on it.
- All users must be able to take a reliable penicillin allergy history and to distinguish a true allergy from an intolerance.
- All users must be competent to weigh a child, because the paediatric macrolide dose is by weight and not by age.
- All users must know that topical and oral antibiotics are NOT to be combined for impetigo.
- All users must previously have supplied medicines under a PGD.
- All users must understand capacity and consent, including Gillick competence and parental responsibility.
- All users must hold appropriate indemnity covering this service, must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer, and must practise only within the bounds of their own competence.

The PGD

Indication	Treatment of localised non-bullous impetigo, being a small number of lesions confined to one area, in accordance with NICE NG153.
Inclusion criteria	• Non-bullous impetigo of limited extent: typically fewer than 5 lesions, or lesions confined to an area under about 5cm. • Systemic treatment not indicated, and the patient not systemically unwell. • Consent obtained, from a person with parental responsibility where the patient is under 16 and not Gillick competent. • No exclusion criterion present.
Exclusion criteria	• Known hypersensitivity to fusidic acid or to any excipient. • Bullous impetigo. Use the oral route. • Widespread impetigo, more than about 5 lesions or lesions covering more than about 5cm. Use the oral route. • Fusidic acid resistance suspected or confirmed. NICE offers mupirocin 2% as the alternative topical; mupirocin is NOT authorised by this PGD, so refer. Refer, do not supply, where any of the following applies. • Systemically unwell: fever, malaise, lymphadenopathy, or the patient appearing unwell. Refer the same day. • Signs of a more serious condition, in particular cellulitis: spreading redness, warmth, swelling, or pain beyond the lesions. Refer to hospital. • Immunocompromised, and impetigo is widespread. NICE advises hospital referral. • Bullous impetigo in a baby. Refer or seek specialist advice. • Recurrent impetigo, meaning frequent repeated episodes. Refer for swabbing and consideration of decolonisation, rather than treating again. • Around the eye, or involving the eyelid margin, where a topical product cannot be used safely and an ophthalmic opinion may be needed. • Diagnostic uncertainty, or a presentation that could be herpes simplex, eczema herpeticum, or a fungal infection. • A course of antibiotic already supplied for this episode under

	this PGD. One course per episode; treatment failure needs reassessment and a swab, not a second guess. Valid informed consent not obtained, or consent from a person with parental responsibility not available where required.
Cautions	Avoid prolonged or repeated use. Extended or recurrent use of topical fusidic acid increases the risk of antimicrobial resistance, which is why NICE positions hydrogen peroxide 1% ahead of it for localised disease. Hydrogen peroxide 1% cream is the NICE initial option for localised non-bullous impetigo, with a topical antibiotic reserved for where it is unsuitable, for example around the eyes, or ineffective. Hydrogen peroxide 1% is a pharmacy medicine and does not require a PGD; offer it as a P sale first where it is appropriate, and record that you did. Do not apply to large body surface areas. Avoid contact with the eyes. If contact occurs, rinse thoroughly with water. Review if no improvement after 48 hours; treatment failure means an oral antibiotic or a swab, not a longer topical course.
Actions if the patient is excluded or declines	Explain why supply is not appropriate and what to do instead. Where the exclusion is widespread or bullous disease, move to the appropriate oral arm rather than referring, provided its criteria are met. Give the hygiene advice regardless. Document the advice and the decision.

The medicine

Name, form and strength	Fusidic acid 2% cream.
Legal category	POM.
Dose and frequency	Apply a thin layer three times a day for 5 days. Cover the lesion and about 1cm of surrounding skin.
Quantity supplied	One 15g tube. No repeat supply under this PGD.
Maximum treatment period	5 days, extended to 7 only on clinical judgement where lesions are severe or numerous, with the reason recorded.
Storage	Store at room temperature, protected from heat. Keep in the original tube with the cap closed.
Adverse effects	Common: local irritation, itching, stinging or burning on application, rash. Rare: hypersensitivity including contact dermatitis and angioedema.
Yellow Card reporting	Report suspected adverse reactions via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP.
Records to be kept	- That valid informed consent was given, and from whom. Where the patient is under 16, the name and relationship of the person with parental responsibility, or the basis of the Gillick assessment. - Patient name, address, date of birth, and the GP with whom they are registered. WHETHER THE IMPETIGO IS LOCALISED OR WIDESPREAD, AND BULLOUS OR NON-BULLOUS, with the number and size of lesions that led to that conclusion. THE PENICILLIN ALLERGY HISTORY in the patient's own terms, and which arm was therefore used. Where a macrolide was supplied to a child: THE WEIGHT IN KILOGRAMS, measured today, and the band it placed the child in. - Pregnancy status where relevant, and how it was established. - Name, form, strength, dose, quantity and date of supply. - That hygiene advice was given, and that the patient was told topical

	and oral treatment are not combined. • Name and registration number of the healthcare professional supplying. • Advice given, including advice given if the patient is excluded or declines. • Details of any adverse drug reactions and the actions taken. • That the medicine was supplied under this PGD. Records signed, dated, legible and contemporaneous. Adults 18 and over: 8 years. Under 18s: until the 25th birthday, or the 26th where the patient was 17 when treatment finished.
Disposal	Advise the patient to return any unused cream to a pharmacy.

Information for the patient

Written information	Supply the patient information leaflet provided with the product, and the hygiene advice in writing.
Counselling	• Apply a thin layer three times a day for 5 days. Wash your hands before and after. • Do not use it for longer than the course, and do not keep the tube for next time. • Impetigo is contagious. Wash hands after touching the lesions and after applying any cream. • Do not share towels, flannels or bedding until the lesions have crusted over or healed. • Keep the lesions covered where practical, and discourage picking or scratching. • Stay away from school or nursery until the lesions are crusted and dry, or for 48 hours after starting an antibiotic. • Keep fingernails short.
Follow-up	Come back if there is no improvement after 48 hours, if the lesions spread, or if you feel unwell.

Flucloxacillin oral suspension, for children 3 months to 18 years who are not penicillin-allergic

Patient Group Direction for the supply of flucloxacillin 250mg/5ml oral suspension for widespread non-bullous impetigo, bullous impetigo, or failure of topical treatment, in children aged 3 months to 18 years.

Healthcare professionals covered, and training

- Pharmacist registered and practising with the GPhC.
- Pharmacy technician registered and practising with the GPhC.
- All users must be familiar with the current SPC for the product supplied, the BNF or BNF for Children, and NICE NG153 on impetigo.
- ALL USERS MUST BE ABLE TO DISTINGUISH LOCALISED FROM WIDESPREAD IMPETIGO, and non-bullous from bullous. Which arm applies turns on it.
- All users must be able to take a reliable penicillin allergy history and to distinguish a true allergy from an intolerance.
- All users must be competent to weigh a child, because the paediatric macrolide dose is by weight and not by age.
- All users must know that topical and oral antibiotics are NOT to be combined for impetigo.
- All users must previously have supplied medicines under a PGD.
- All users must understand capacity and consent, including Gillick competence and parental responsibility.
- All users must hold appropriate indemnity covering this service, must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer, and must practise only within the bounds of their own competence.

The PGD

Indication	Treatment of widespread non-bullous impetigo, bullous impetigo, or impetigo that has failed topical treatment, in a child aged 3 months to 18 years who is not penicillin-allergic.
Inclusion criteria	• Aged 3 months to 18 years. • Widespread non-bullous impetigo, bullous impetigo, or failure of topical therapy after 48 hours. • Able to take an oral medicine. • NOT penicillin-allergic. Where the child is, use the macrolide arm. • Consent obtained from a person with parental responsibility, or from the young person where Gillick competent. • No exclusion criterion present.
Exclusion criteria	• Known penicillin allergy of any type, or flucloxacillin hypersensitivity. Use the macrolide arm. • Cephalosporin allergy with a high risk of cross-reactivity to penicillins. • Previous cholestasis or jaundice associated with flucloxacillin. • Severe hepatic impairment, or severe renal impairment (eGFR below 30 mL/min/1.73m²). • Under 3 months of age. Refer. • Adults aged 18 and over. This arm is a paediatric oral suspension and this PGD carries no adult oral flucloxacillin. Refer. Refer, do not supply, where any of the following applies. • Systemically unwell: fever, malaise, lymphadenopathy, or the patient appearing unwell. Refer the same day. • Signs of a more serious condition, in particular cellulitis: spreading redness, warmth, swelling, or pain beyond the lesions. Refer to hospital. • Immunocompromised, and impetigo is widespread. NICE advises hospital referral. • Bullous impetigo in a baby. Refer or seek specialist advice. • Recurrent impetigo, meaning frequent repeated episodes. Refer for swabbing and consideration of decolonisation, rather than

	treating again. • Around the eye, or involving the eyelid margin, where a topical product cannot be used safely and an ophthalmic opinion may be needed. • Diagnostic uncertainty, or a presentation that could be herpes simplex, eczema herpeticum, or a fungal infection. • A course of antibiotic already supplied for this episode under this PGD. One course per episode; treatment failure needs reassessment and a swab, not a second guess. • Valid informed consent not obtained, or consent from a person with parental responsibility not available where required.
Cautions	Flucloxacillin can rarely cause cholestatic hepatitis, which may present up to two months after treatment. Advise the family to seek advice for jaundice, dark urine or pale stools, including after the course has finished. Take on an empty stomach, an hour before food or two hours after, because food reduces absorption. Gastrointestinal upset is common. Advise on severe or bloody diarrhoea and the possibility of <i>Clostridioides difficile</i>. The suspension is unpalatable and a common reason for a course not being finished. Where the child will not take it, the macrolide arm is a reasonable alternative on grounds of unsuitability, as NICE allows.
Actions if the patient is excluded or declines	As for the other arms. Where the exclusion is penicillin allergy or an unpalatable suspension, move to the macrolide arm rather than referring, provided its criteria are met.

The medicine

Name, form and strength	Flucloxacillin 250mg/5ml oral suspension.
Legal category	POM.
Dose and frequency	• 1 month to 1 year: 62.5mg to 125mg four times a day for 5 days. • 2 to 9 years: 125mg to 250mg four times a day for 5 days. • 10 to 17 years: 250mg to 500mg four times a day for 5 days. • Four times a day means four times a day. A three-times-daily regimen is a common error and underdoses the child.
Quantity supplied	One bottle sufficient for a 5 day course at the dose selected. No repeat supply under this PGD.
Maximum treatment period	5 days, extended to 7 only on clinical judgement, with the reason recorded.
Route and method	Oral, on an empty stomach.
Storage	Store the dry powder at room temperature. After reconstitution, refrigerate and discard after the period stated in the SPC.
Adverse effects	Common: nausea, diarrhoea, rash. Rare but serious: cholestatic jaundice and hepatitis, which may be delayed; anaphylaxis; severe cutaneous reactions; antibiotic-associated colitis.
Yellow Card reporting	Report suspected adverse reactions via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP.
Records to be kept	• That valid informed consent was given, and from whom. Where the patient is under 16, the name and relationship of the person with parental responsibility, or the basis of the Gillick assessment. • Patient name, address, date of birth, and the GP with whom they are

	registered. ● WHETHER THE IMPETIGO IS LOCALISED OR WIDESPREAD, AND BULLOUS OR NON-BULLOUS, with the number and size of lesions that led to that conclusion. ● THE PENICILLIN ALLERGY HISTORY in the patient's own terms, and which arm was therefore used. ● Where a macrolide was supplied to a child: THE WEIGHT IN KILOGRAMS, measured today, and the band it placed the child in. ● Pregnancy status where relevant, and how it was established. ● Name, form, strength, dose, quantity and date of supply. ● That hygiene advice was given, and that the patient was told topical and oral treatment are not combined. ● Name and registration number of the healthcare professional supplying. ● Advice given, including advice given if the patient is excluded or declines. ● Details of any adverse drug reactions and the actions taken. ● That the medicine was supplied under this PGD. Records signed, dated, legible and contemporaneous. Adults 18 and over: 8 years. Under 18s: until the 25th birthday, or the 26th where the patient was 17 when treatment finished.
Disposal	Advise return of any unused suspension to a pharmacy.

Information for the patient

Written information	Supply the patient information leaflet and the hygiene advice in writing.
Counselling	● Four times a day, on an empty stomach: an hour before food or two hours after. ● Finish the course even if the skin looks better. ● Come back for yellowing of the skin or eyes, dark urine or pale stools, even weeks after finishing. ● Impetigo is contagious. Wash hands after touching the lesions and after applying any cream. ● Do not share towels, flannels or bedding until the lesions have crusted over or healed. ● Keep the lesions covered where practical, and discourage picking or scratching. ● Stay away from school or nursery until the lesions are crusted and dry, or for 48 hours after starting an antibiotic. ● Keep fingernails short.
Follow-up	Come back if there is no improvement after 48 to 72 hours, if the lesions spread, or if the child becomes unwell.

Macrolide, for penicillin-allergic patients

Patient Group Direction for the supply of clarithromycin, or erythromycin in pregnancy, for widespread non-bullous impetigo, bullous impetigo, or failure of topical treatment, where the patient is penicillin-allergic or flucloxacillin is unsuitable.

New in version 002. Version 001 had no route for a penicillin-allergic patient needing an oral antibiotic, while the ePGD tool was recommending clarithromycin with nothing authorising it.

Healthcare professionals covered, and training

- Pharmacist registered and practising with the GPhC.
- Pharmacy technician registered and practising with the GPhC.
- All users must be familiar with the current SPC for the product supplied, the BNF or BNF for Children, and NICE NG153 on impetigo.
- ALL USERS MUST BE ABLE TO DISTINGUISH LOCALISED FROM WIDESPREAD IMPETIGO, and non-bullous from bullous. Which arm applies turns on it.
- All users must be able to take a reliable penicillin allergy history and to distinguish a true allergy from an intolerance.
- All users must be competent to weigh a child, because the paediatric macrolide dose is by weight and not by age.
- All users must know that topical and oral antibiotics are NOT to be combined for impetigo.
- All users must previously have supplied medicines under a PGD.
- All users must understand capacity and consent, including Gillick competence and parental responsibility.
- All users must hold appropriate indemnity covering this service, must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer, and must practise only within the bounds of their own competence.

The PGD

Indication	Treatment of widespread non-bullous impetigo, bullous impetigo, or impetigo that has failed topical treatment, where the patient is penicillin-allergic or flucloxacillin is otherwise unsuitable, in accordance with NICE NG153.
Inclusion criteria	• Aged 1 month and over. There is no upper age limit. • Widespread non-bullous impetigo, bullous impetigo, or failure of topical therapy after 48 hours. • Penicillin-allergic, or flucloxacillin unsuitable, for example an oral suspension the child will not take. Record which applies. • Where the patient is a child: WEIGHED TODAY, in kilograms, and the weight recorded. The dose is by weight, not by age. • Able to take an oral medicine. • Consent obtained, from a person with parental responsibility where the patient is under 16 and not Gillick competent. • No exclusion criterion present.
Exclusion criteria: clarithromycin interactions and contraindications	These are contraindications in the SPC, not cautions. Refer. • Taking SIMVASTATIN or LOVASTATIN. Clarithromycin raises their levels and the combination causes myopathy and rhabdomyolysis. Do not supply, and do not advise the patient to simply stop their statin; that is a prescriber decision. • Taking COLCHICINE. Deaths from colchicine toxicity have been reported with the combination, particularly in older patients and those with renal impairment. • Taking an ERGOT ALKALOID: ergotamine or dihydroergotamine. Acute ergot toxicity with vasospasm and tissue ischaemia has been reported. • Taking TICAGRELOR. • History of QT prolongation, congenital or acquired, or of ventricular arrhythmia including torsades de pointes. • Taking any other medicine known to prolong the QT interval, or with hypokalaemia. • Known hypersensitivity to clarithromycin or to any macrolide.

	Severe hepatic failure with renal impairment.
Exclusion criteria: all other	- Under 1 month of age. Refer. Pregnant, and erythromycin is not suitable or not available. Erythromycin is the macrolide of choice in pregnancy, there being more documented experience of its use. Do not substitute clarithromycin. - Breastfeeding, unless the choice has been discussed and recorded. A child who cannot be weighed today. Do not estimate from age. Refer, do not supply, where any of the following applies. Systemically unwell: fever, malaise, lymphadenopathy, or the patient appearing unwell. Refer the same day. Signs of a more serious condition, in particular cellulitis: spreading redness, warmth, swelling, or pain beyond the lesions. Refer to hospital. Immunocompromised, and impetigo is widespread. NICE advises hospital referral. Bullous impetigo in a baby. Refer or seek specialist advice. Recurrent impetigo, meaning frequent repeated episodes. Refer for swabbing and consideration of decolonisation, rather than treating again. - Around the eye, or involving the eyelid margin, where a topical product cannot be used safely and an ophthalmic opinion may be needed. Diagnostic uncertainty, or a presentation that could be herpes simplex, eczema herpeticum, or a fungal infection. A course of antibiotic already supplied for this episode under this PGD. One course per episode; treatment failure needs reassessment and a swab, not a second guess. - Valid informed consent not obtained, or consent from a person with parental responsibility not available where required.
Cautions	Take a proper penicillin allergy history. A patient labelled penicillin-allergic on the basis of childhood nausea is losing access to a better antibiotic, but this is not the consultation in which to unpick that. Record what the patient describes and use this arm. Advise on gastrointestinal upset and taste disturbance, which are common with clarithromycin. Advise the patient to seek advice for severe or bloody diarrhoea, which may indicate <i>Clostridioides difficile</i>. Warn about rash, and to stop and seek advice for any blistering or peeling. Where the patient takes any statin other than simvastatin or lovastatin, or warfarin, check the current BNF: dose adjustment or monitoring may be needed and referral may be the safer course.
Actions if the patient is excluded or declines	Explain the reason plainly. Where the exclusion is an interacting medicine, say that the problem is the antibiotic and not the skin infection, and make sure the referral happens the same day so the impetigo is still treated. Give the hygiene advice regardless.

The medicine

Name, form and strength	Clarithromycin 250mg tablets, or clarithromycin 125mg/5ml or 250mg/5ml oral suspension for children. Erythromycin 250mg tablets or oral suspension, for use in pregnancy.
Legal category	POM.
Dose and frequency: CLARITHROMYCIN	Adults, young people and children aged 12 to 17 years: 250mg twice a day for 5 days. May be increased to 500mg twice a day for severe infection, with the reason recorded.

	Children aged 1 month to 11 years, BY WEIGHT: • Under 8kg: 7.5mg/kg twice a day for 5 days. • 8 to 11kg: 62.5mg twice a day for 5 days. • 12 to 19kg: 125mg twice a day for 5 days. • 20 to 29kg: 187.5mg twice a day for 5 days. • 30 to 40kg: 250mg twice a day for 5 days. Weigh the child. Do not estimate from age. The bands assume a child of average size and the weight is what selects the dose.
Dose and frequency: ERYTHROMYCIN, in pregnancy	• Adults: 250mg to 500mg four times a day for 5 days. • Aged 8 to 17 years: 250mg to 500mg four times a day for 5 days. • Erythromycin is the macrolide of choice in pregnancy because there is more documented experience of its use than for other macrolides.
Quantity supplied	Sufficient for a 5 day course at the dose and formulation selected. No repeat supply under this PGD.
Maximum treatment period	5 days, extended to 7 only on clinical judgement where lesions are severe or numerous, with the reason recorded.
Route and method	Oral. Clarithromycin may be taken with or without food. Shake any suspension before use.
Storage	Store in accordance with the SPC for the product supplied. Refrigerate reconstituted suspensions where the SPC requires it and discard after the stated period.
Drug interactions	See the exclusion criteria: simvastatin, lovastatin, colchicine, ergot alkaloids, ticagrelor and QT-prolonging medicines are contraindications rather than cautions. Also check warfarin, other statins, digoxin, midazolam, ciclosporin, tacrolimus and antiepileptics against the current BNF and SPC.
Adverse effects	Common: abdominal pain, nausea, vomiting, diarrhoea, taste disturbance, headache, rash. Uncommon: candidiasis, raised liver enzymes. Rare but serious: QT prolongation and ventricular arrhythmia including torsades de pointes, hepatitis and cholestatic jaundice, Stevens-Johnson syndrome and toxic epidermal necrolysis, anaphylaxis, Clostridioides difficile colitis, hearing loss which is usually reversible.
Yellow Card reporting	Report suspected adverse reactions via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP.
Records to be kept	• That valid informed consent was given, and from whom. Where the patient is under 16, the name and relationship of the person with parental responsibility, or the basis of the Gillick assessment. • Patient name, address, date of birth, and the GP with whom they are registered. • WHETHER THE IMPETIGO IS LOCALISED OR WIDESPREAD, AND BULLOUS OR NON-BULLOUS, with the number and size of lesions that led to that conclusion. • THE PENICILLIN ALLERGY HISTORY in the patient's own terms, and which arm was therefore used. • Where a macrolide was supplied to a child: THE WEIGHT IN KILOGRAMS, measured today, and the band it placed the child in. • Pregnancy status where relevant, and how it was established. • Name, form, strength, dose, quantity and date of supply. • That hygiene advice was given, and that the patient was told topical and oral treatment are not combined. • Name and registration number of the healthcare professional supplying.

	● Advice given, including advice given if the patient is excluded or declines. ● Details of any adverse drug reactions and the actions taken. ● That the medicine was supplied under this PGD. Records signed, dated, legible and contemporaneous. Adults 18 and over: 8 years. Under 18s: until the 25th birthday, or the 26th where the patient was 17 when treatment finished.
Disposal	Advise return of any unused medicine to a pharmacy.

Information for the patient

Written information	Supply the patient information leaflet for the product given, and the hygiene advice in writing.
Counselling	● Clarithromycin: twice a day for 5 days. Erythromycin: four times a day for 5 days. Finish the course. ● A metallic or bitter taste is common with clarithromycin and settles when you stop. ● Come back for severe or bloody diarrhoea, a rash that blisters or peels, or yellowing of the skin or eyes. ● Impetigo is contagious. Wash hands after touching the lesions and after applying any cream. ● Do not share towels, flannels or bedding until the lesions have crusted over or healed. ● Keep the lesions covered where practical, and discourage picking or scratching. ● Stay away from school or nursery until the lesions are crusted and dry, or for 48 hours after starting an antibiotic. ● Keep fingernails short.
Follow-up	Come back if there is no improvement after 48 to 72 hours, if the lesions spread, or if you or your child becomes unwell.

Appendix 1: Which arm, in order

1. Is the patient systemically unwell, or is there cellulitis?	• YES: refer, same day or to hospital. Stop here.
2. Is it localised non-bullous impetigo?	• YES: consider hydrogen peroxide 1% as a P sale first. If unsuitable or ineffective, fusidic acid 2% cream, three times a day for 5 days. • NO: go to 3.
3. Widespread, bullous, or topical treatment has failed. Is the patient penicillin-allergic?	• NO, and aged 3 months to 18 years: flucloxacillin oral suspension, four times a day for 5 days. • NO, and an adult: refer. This PGD has no adult oral flucloxacillin arm. • YES: go to 4.
4. Penicillin-allergic. Is the patient pregnant?	• NO: clarithromycin. Adults and 12 to 17 years, 250mg twice a day for 5 days. Children 1 month to 11 years, by weight. • YES: erythromycin 250mg to 500mg four times a day for 5 days. • Check the clarithromycin contraindications first: simvastatin, lovastatin, colchicine, ergot alkaloids, ticagrelor, QT prolongation.
5. In every case	• Do NOT combine a topical and an oral antibiotic. • Give the hygiene advice. • One course per episode. Treatment failure needs a swab, not a second guess.

Appendix 2: Key references

- NICE NG153: Impetigo, antimicrobial prescribing, published 26 February 2020.
- NICE Clinical Knowledge Summary: Impetigo, including hygiene measures.
- Summary of Product Characteristics for fusidic acid 2% cream, flucloxacillin 250mg/5ml oral suspension, clarithromycin and erythromycin, current versions.
- British National Formulary and BNF for Children.
- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions, <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2>

Authorisation

Version	v002
Supersedes	Version 001, 1 November 2025
Valid from date	8 September 2026
Expiry date	31 July 2027

Doctor	Name: Nitin Shori Job title: Medical Director, Get Real Health GMC: 6047293 Signed: N. Shori Date: 8 September 2026
Pharmacist	Name: Chris Pilkington Job title: Head Pharmacist, Get Real Health GPhC: 2046322

	Signed: C. Pilkington Date: 8 September 2026
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Both authorising signatories reviewed this version together on 8 September 2026 and gave their authorisation for it to be issued. Signatures were applied digitally on their joint instruction, which is the established process for Get Real Health PGDs.

Adoption by the employing organisation

To be completed by the adopting pharmacy. These signatories are the adopting organisation own signatories and must not be pre-filled by Get Real Health.

Superintendent / clinical lead	Name: Job title and organisation: Signature: Date:
Professional group signatory	Name: Job title and organisation: Signature: Date:

Change history

Version	v002
Date	8 September 2026
Changes	• A macrolide arm is added for penicillin-allergic patients: clarithromycin, or erythromycin in pregnancy, per NICE NG153. Version 001 authorised fusidic acid and flucloxacillin only, and its flucloxacillin arm excluded penicillin allergy, so a penicillin-allergic patient with widespread or bullous impetigo had no route at all. • Full paediatric clarithromycin weight bands stated, from under 8kg to 30 to 40kg, with a requirement to weigh the child today rather than estimate from age. • Erythromycin named as the macrolide of choice in pregnancy, with clarithromycin excluded there. • Clarithromycin contraindications handled as exclusions rather than cautions: simvastatin, lovastatin, colchicine, ergot alkaloids, ticagrelor, and any history of QT prolongation or ventricular arrhythmia. • Course length corrected to 5 days throughout, extended to 7 only on clinical judgement with the reason recorded. Version 001 gave 5 to 7 days as the default. • An explicit instruction not to combine topical and oral antibiotics, which NICE states and which was absent. • Hydrogen peroxide 1% named as the NICE initial option for localised non-bullous impetigo, and identified as a P medicine that does not require a PGD, so it is offered as a pharmacy sale rather than added as an arm. • Mupirocin identified as the NICE alternative topical where fusidic acid resistance is suspected, and expressly NOT authorised by this PGD, so that a pharmacist reaching for it refers instead. • Shared exclusions added across all three arms: systemic illness, cellulitis, immunocompromise with widespread disease, bullous impetigo in a baby, recurrent impetigo, eye involvement, diagnostic uncertainty including herpes simplex and eczema herpeticum, and one course per episode. • Recorded as an unresolved limitation rather than fixed: the flucloxacillin arm remains a paediatric oral suspension for ages 3 months to 18 years, so there is still no adult oral flucloxacillin. A penicillin-tolerant adult needing an oral antibiotic is referred. • Records must now carry whether the impetigo was localised or widespread and bullous or non-bullous with the findings behind that, the penicillin allergy history, and the measured weight where a child was given a macrolide.

Previous versions

001, 1 November 2025	Development and issue of new PGD. Fusidic acid 2% cream for localised non-bullous impetigo, and flucloxacillin 250mg/5ml oral suspension for widespread or bullous disease in children aged 3 months to 18 years. Penicillin allergy excluded from the oral arm with no alternative provided.
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